The spiritual well-being of individuals is followed in the Fourth Edict, which takes up how the harshest punishments handed out by the administration might be mitigated. The edict is primarily concerned with making the rajukkas functionally autonomous. These officials, as noted in relation to the minor rock edicts, had been ordered to disseminate the Ashokan message in the countryside. Now in this edict their authority over rural people is reemphasized, for they are to be ‘occupied with the people, with many hundreds and thousands’ of people.[24] The rajukka is a state equivalent of the nurse that parents put their faith in when caring for children: ‘For, as one feels confident after having entrusted (his) child to an intelligent nurse, (thinking): “the intelligent nurse will be able to keep my child well”, so that Rajukas were appointed by me for the welfare and happiness of the country-people.’[25] His faith in these officials is clear for he grants them independence in the discharge of their judicial functions: ‘rewards or punishment are left to their discretion, in order that *Lajukas* perform (their) duties confidently (and) fearlessly, that they should bestow welfare and happiness on the people of the country, and that they should confer benefits (on them).’[26] Ashoka is at pains to emphasize that these are moral guardians to whom he is delegating full responsibility for the common weal.[27] The intent is, for the time, rather amazing and is described by a legal scholar as ‘an extraordinarily progressive measure for its time, amounting to a guarantee of due process of law.’[28] The rajukkas were responsible for justice outside the cities, so the endeavour seems to have been to ensure consistency in the judicial process.

This also raises questions: had the king’s proactive administrative measures demoralized the state machinery? Had there been a weakening in the administration now being redressed? Why was such functional autonomy being granted only to officers in charge of the countryside? The mahamatras who acted as judges in the city had in relation to Kalinga been exhorted to be more sensitive, proactive, and even-handed. The emperor